

suggests a simple phrase you can use to challenge and help make sense of your potentially ‘magical thinking’. It goes like this: ‘The story I’m making up is ...’ You might consider using this tool as you start to test whether the Money Stories you’re uncovering are helpful ones you want to take with you or whether they’re myths or even pure bullshit.

As you consider each story that makes up your Money Story, use Brené’s phrase to take it through to the eventual consequence. If, for example, the story is around the fact that in order to be an adult you need to own your own home, change that to, ‘The story I’m making up is that I can’t be an adult if I don’t own my own home.’ By using Brené’s phrase, you’re reframing the Money Story and deciding whether it’s still true in this new light. If it still rings true then keep it. If it doesn’t then reject it and decide what you want that Money Story to be instead. For example, you might reject the above but make the rewrite: ‘In order to reach my own version of financial adulthood, I need to have clear three year goals and be enacting a savings plan to ensure I reach those goals.’ Or maybe it’s: ‘I believe it’s important to own property but it doesn’t need to be my own home.’

It’s a powerful phrase, which is why I want you to use it when it comes to your own Money Story and your relationship with money. Even better, if you do the work with your partner, your friends or your family, it can become a powerful tool you can all use to identify stories you’re making up with each other, whether it’s with your Money Stories or life stories generally. That’s because, too often, ‘the story I’m making up’ isn’t helpful or even true—and it may be keeping you from your financial potential. By vocalising and challenging our Money Story in this way, we can confront it and see it for what it is, rather than allowing it to subconsciously direct our responses. We can start to direct our fate rather than living by default.

Returning to the examples from earlier in the chapter, imagine if Jacqui, Cathie or I had kept on believing our learned Money Stories. In Jacqui’s case, it would have led to more physical breakdowns and possibly failed health. Cathie might not have become a billionaire, and I’d be stuck unhealthily playing it small and safe—unable to achieve the financial options and impact I really wanted. In all our cases, believing our Money Stories would have meant we would be working so much harder but ultimately for far less financial return and far less freedom.